

# Urban Visions

How can we develop a sustainability plan to ensure a selected region is future-ready?

Grade

9-12

Subjects

Social Studies

Estimated Duration

15-20 instructional  
hours

Key Content

geography, human  
impacts,  
urbanization, culture  
and environment



Students work together to unpack and understand United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 11. Teams select a low performing focus city from the 2019 U.S. Cities Sustainable Development report, research the city's past and present development, then create a sustainability plan that proposes how to ensure development will be inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable for future generations. Students present their plan to local council members and community planners in a town hall meeting, and discuss implications for their own community.

## Project Path

### Project Launch

*Why is sustainable city development important?*

Launch project by analyzing images and exploring sustainable cities.

### Build Knowledge and Develop & Critique

*How are cities around the world addressing urbanization issues, and what can we learn from their solutions?*

Investigate how global cities are putting sustainability practices into action, and determine recommendations for the focus city.

*What key ideas should we integrate into our final product to illustrate the complexity and urgency of the issue?*

Finalize the team's sustainability plan and prepare a presentation.

*What challenges does urbanization create and how are cities planning to address these challenges?*

Review sustainability plans from around the world to become familiar with sustainable development strategies.

*How can past practices inform and direct future planning?*

Use the workshop model to explore different geographical concepts and summarize the focus city's past development approaches.

## Present Products

*How can we share our learning with others?*

Present plans to town council members and local community planners.

## Make It Yours

### Reflect on your students

- What issues do students connect with that affect citizens globally?
- How might you make this topic relevant to students who have limited experience in cities?
- How can student groups be designed to match student interests and integrate multiple perspectives and backgrounds?

### Reflect on your context

- Can you find community experts in the fields of urban planning, sustainable infrastructure, or green energy?
- Are there local organizations (such as the city council, Department of Urban Planning, Lions Club, or a local university or college) that might serve as community partners and help participate in a public audience for presentations?
- What local connections can you make to issues of migration, gender, land, housing, and energy use?

### Reflect on the content & skills

- How will you check for understanding and guide students through their individual research investigations?
- How might you teach students effective research skills for evaluating sources and citing them correctly?
- What scaffolds might be helpful to students as they write sustainability plans?
- How will you prepare students to respond clearly and confidently to questions from the audience?

# Take It Further

Here are ideas for expanding this project, should you choose to do so:

- Take students on a virtual field trip to a mega-city and see the impacts of urbanization, use a virtual reality platform such as Nearpod (<https://nearpod.com/nearpod-vr>) or Google Expeditions (<https://artsandculture.google.com/project/expeditions>). Have students draw a mind map in small groups to brainstorm topics related to the complexities of urbanization.
- Based on the connections you have to local institutions and technology capacities, consider inviting a guest speaker (virtually or in-person) with experience in urban planning or sustainable design to speak about their experiences with urbanization.
- Within teams, choose a role to provide a specific question set for each team member to research and answer: historian, environmental impact officer, social anthropologist, policy expert, urban economist, and urban planner.

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*Thank you to Kristyn Kamps, Kelli Boender, and Susanna Pierce McConnell for development on this project.*